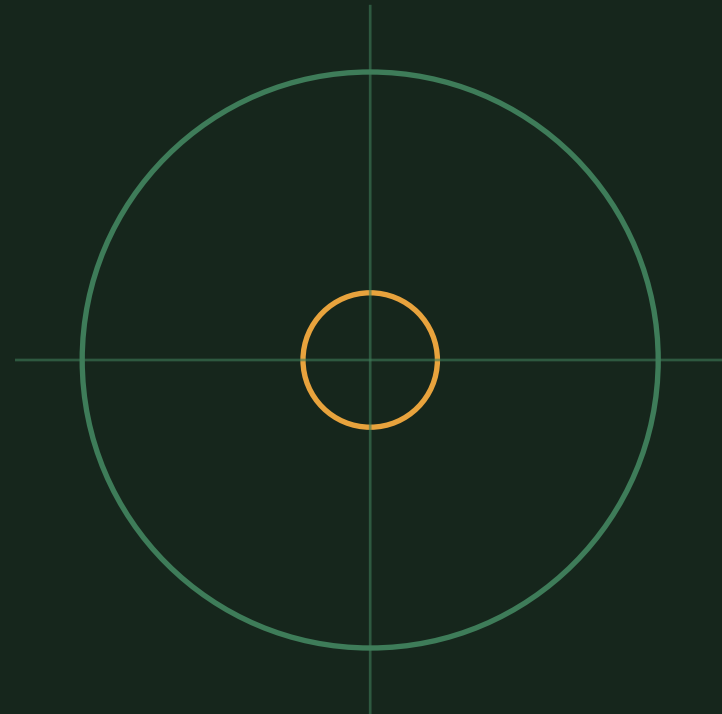


DEAD KEYS

A Typing-Action Zombie Defense Game

Type to load ammo. Aim to spend it. No lock-on, no shortcuts.



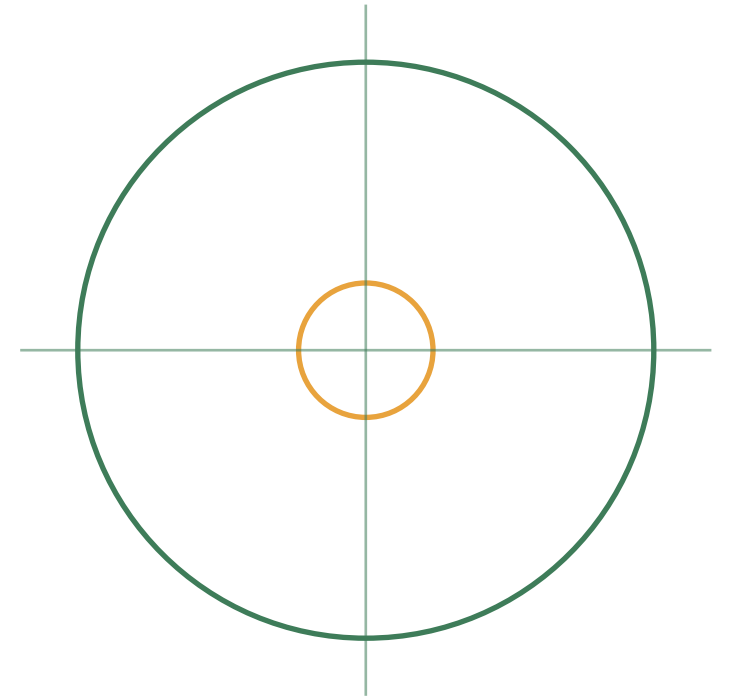
What Is Dead Keys?

A 2D top-down zombie-defense game for PC. You're stationed at a fixed base, defending it across six missions as an outbreak spreads through a city.

Every zombie carries a word above its head. Type it to load a bullet, then aim with the mouse and fire it yourself. Typing never damages anything directly, and there's no lock-on when you shoot.

“Typing loads your gun. It never fires it.”

Closest comparisons: Epistory / ZType for the typing hook, Plants vs. Zombies for the base-defense tone. Dead Keys splits typing and damage apart, neither of those does.



Three Design Pillars

Every feature in the game has to serve one of these, or it gets cut.

1

**Typing earns,
aiming spends**

Typing and damage are never the same action.

2

**Choose your run
before you start it**

Build variety lives in a pre-mission menu,
not mid-run pickups.

3

**Mistakes cost
something now**

Typing errors have an immediate, visible,
in-combat consequence.

The Core Loop



Moment (2-4 s)

Word appears → type it → aim → fire



Session (4-8 min)

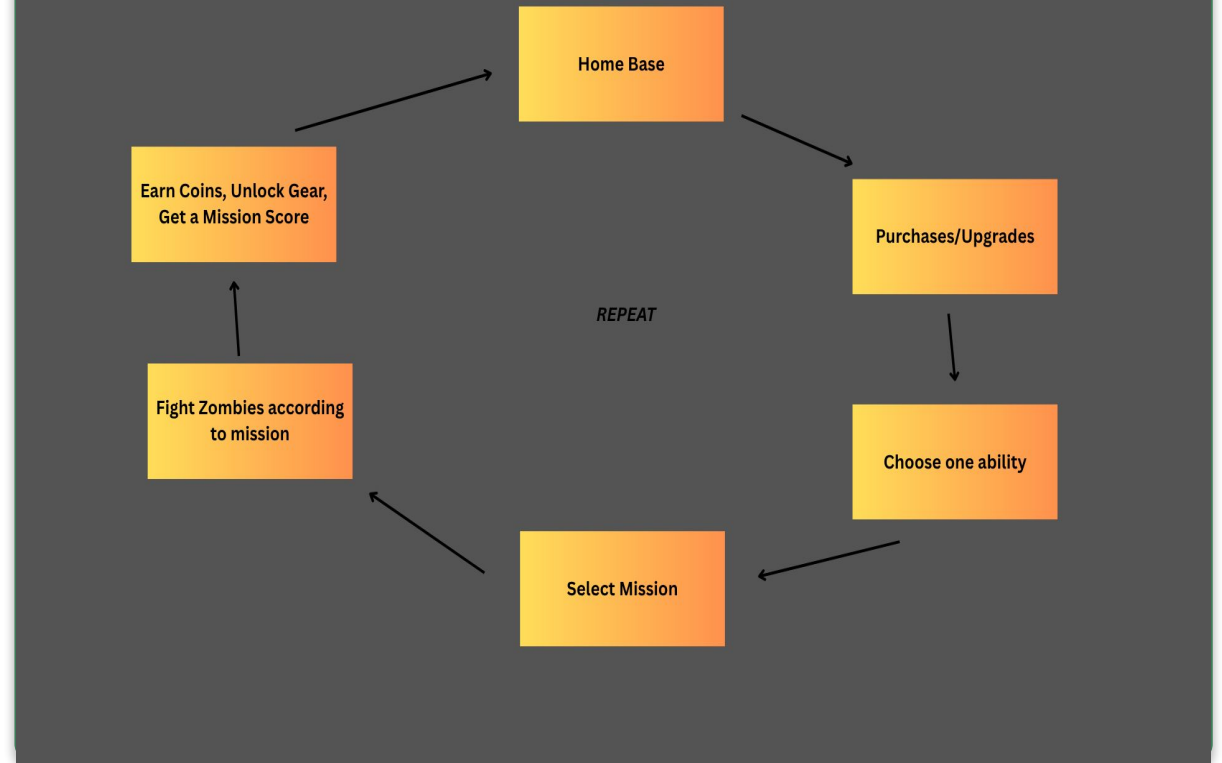
One full mission, ending in a rating screen



Meta (hours)

Home Base → upgrades → mission → repeat

Fig 1: Core Gameplay Loop



Type to Load. Aim to Fire.

Word length sets how much ammo you get, nothing else:

3-4 letters (e.g. CAT)

1 bullet

5-7 letters (e.g. GARDEN)

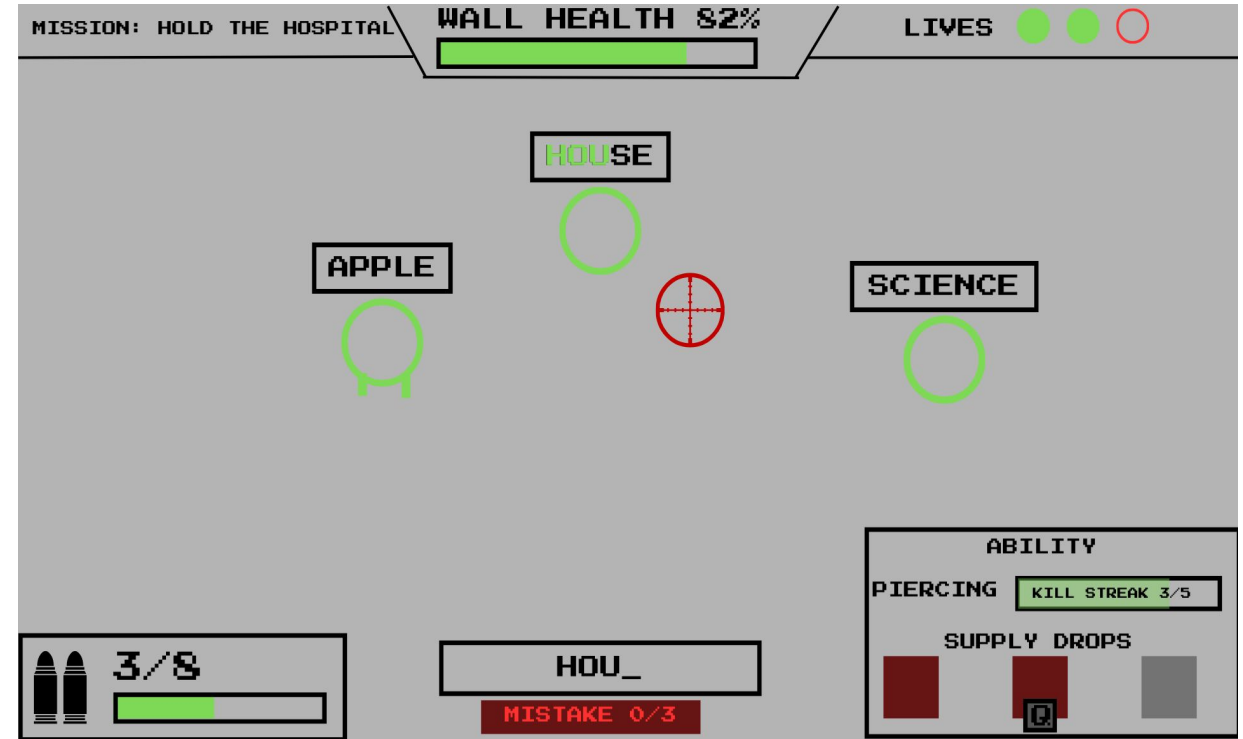
2 bullets

8-10 letters (e.g. HOSPITAL)

3 bullets

11+ letters (e.g. EXTRAORDINARY)

5 bullets



No auto-fire. No lock-on. Missed shots waste ammo you worked for.

Mistakes Cost Something, Now

One primary punishment, one secondary, so it stays readable mid-combat.

1

bullet lost

per typo, straight from the current magazine

2s

weapon jam

after 3 consecutive mistakes, fire is locked out

Choose Your Loadout

Fig 3: Pre mission ability loadout screen



One ability, chosen before the mission. Locked in once it starts, no switching, no stacking.



Spread Shot

next shot fires in a cone



Piercing Shot

Passes through every enemy in a line



Freeze Round

Freezes a zombie that is hit with this round for set amount of time



Ricochet

Bounces and hits a set amount of zombies

Call In Mission Supplies

Buy up to 3 crates before a mission. Call one in whenever you need it, then type the crate's word before it expires.



Ammo Crate

Refills ammo and grants a flat bonus



Medical Crate

Repairs a chunk of wall health, nothing else



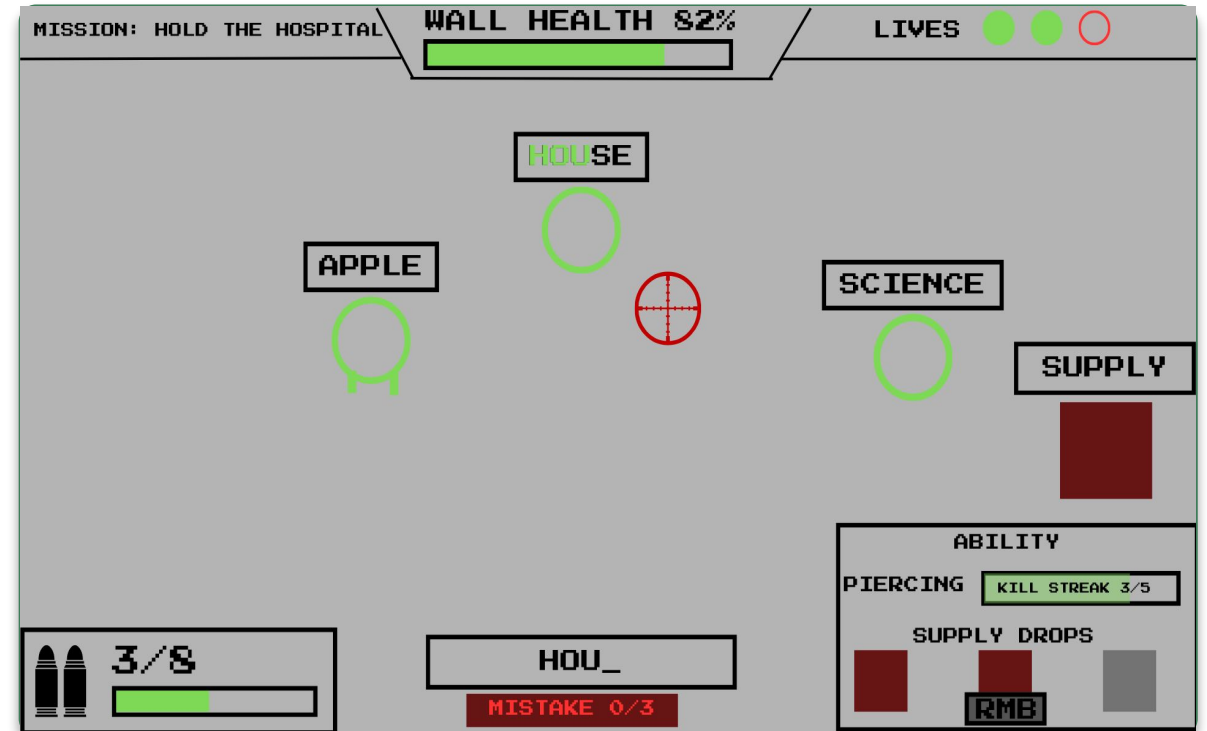
Combat Crate

Temporary damage boost

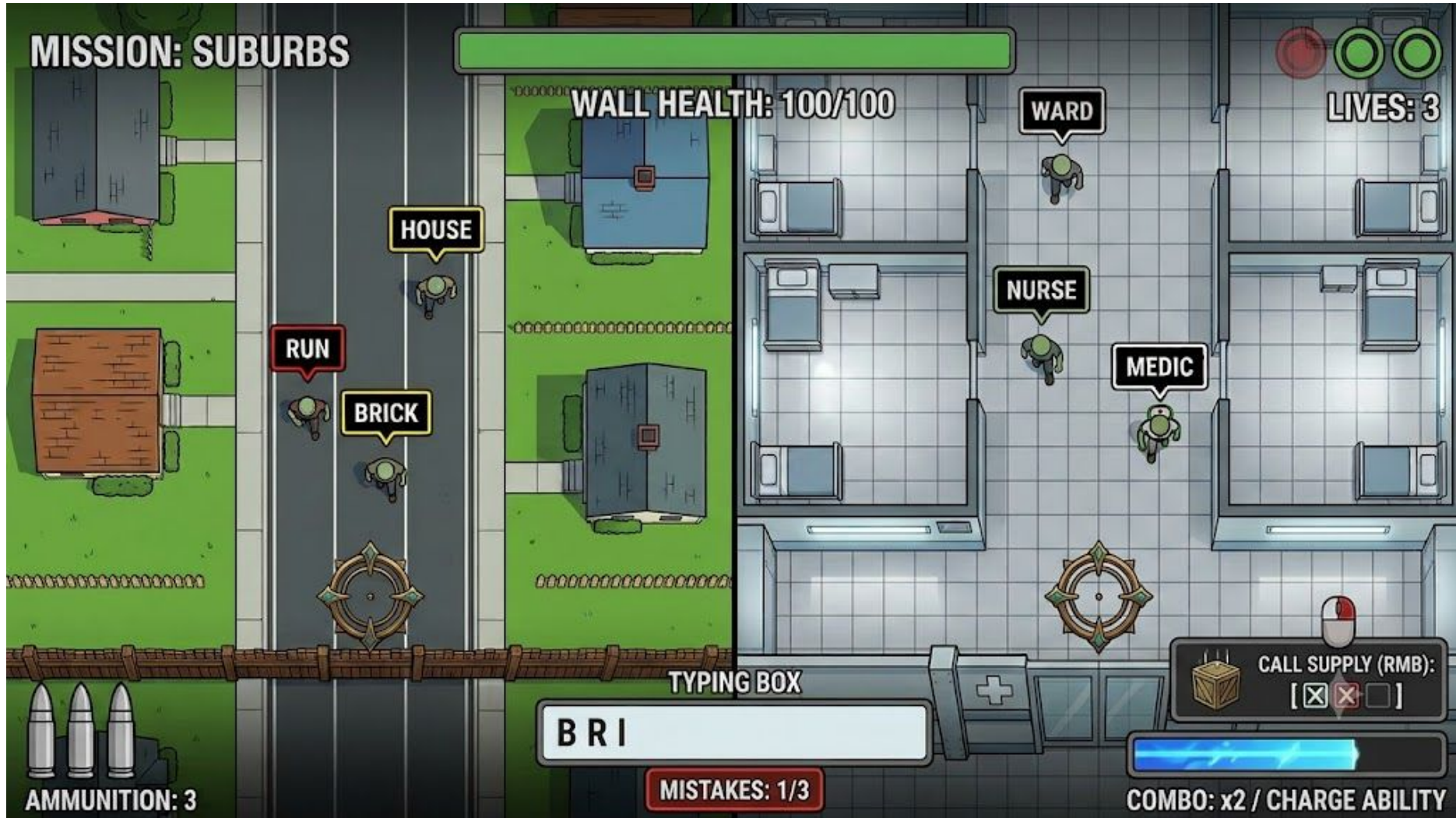


Emergency Crate

Clears a weapon jam and refills ammo, the panic button

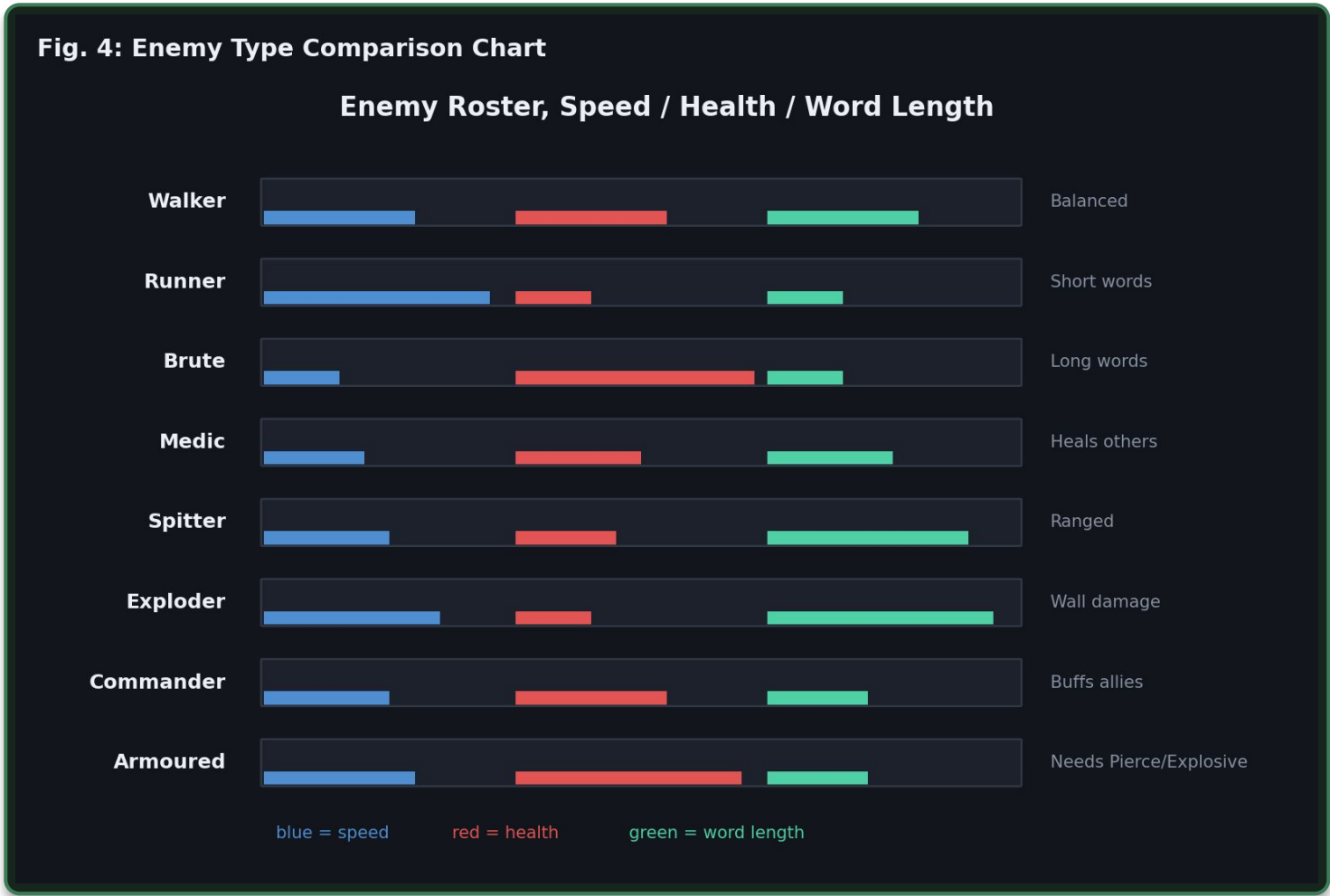


Gemini AI Generated Mockup of how the first two levels could look



Eight Enemy Types

Differentiated by speed, health, and word length, so the same core loop reads very differently per wave.

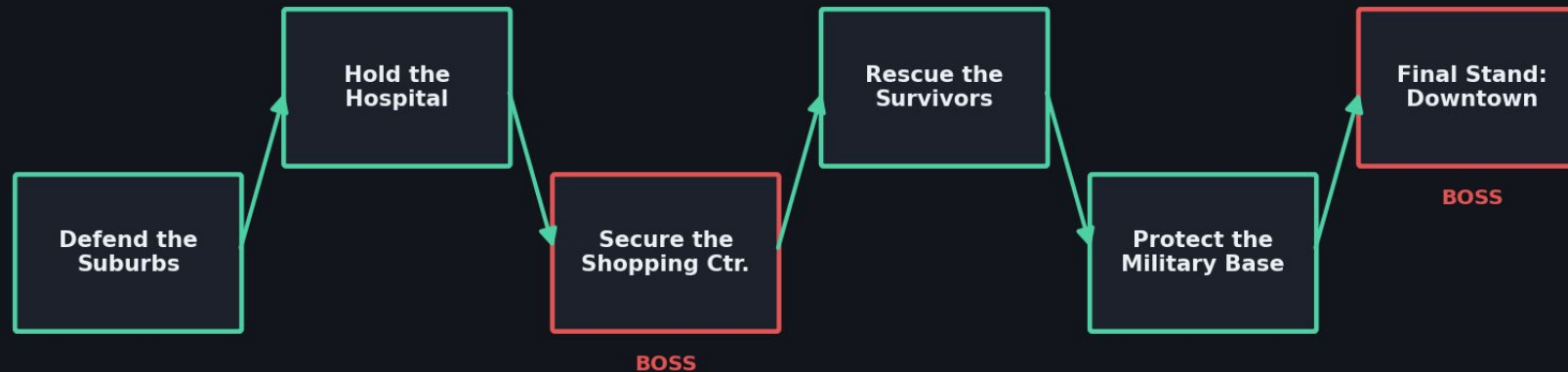


Six Missions, Rising Difficulty

Suburbs → Hospital → Shopping Centre → Rescue → Military Base → Downtown. More enemies, longer words, harsher mistake penalties.

Fig. 5: Mission Progression

Difficulty increases: more enemies, longer words, harsher mistake penalties



Built to Be Playable by More People

Accessibility is design-time, not a patch-time afterthought.



Assist modes, not shame

Word-difficulty and approach pace assist, named as player choices and worded nicely, not an “easy mode”



Colour-safe

Enemy types read by silhouette and label border, never colour alone; palette checked for colour-blindness



Remappable controls

Mouse sensitivity and rebinding fire to a non letter key, e.g. Space or F1 to ensure no overlapping with words in the game



Visual Effects

Visual Effects can be turned off for visual conditions



Readable at a glance

16pt minimum text at 1080p for floating words, larger than standard UI text

Known limitation, said out loud: typing keys themselves can't be remapped, since they have to match the word on screen. Assist modes are the mitigation, not a fix.

Built in Godot, Shipped in 10 Weeks

Engine	Godot 4.7, GDScript
Platforms	Windows, Linux, macOS
Content	Data-driven word lists & missions (.tres/JSON)
Testing	GUT unit tests + GitLab CI on every push

Scope discipline

Vertical slice (Wk 6-8) carries the most risk solo. If it overruns, the second boss and half the ability roster are cut first, never the mistake system or the typing/shooting split, since those are the game's actual identity.

Course Milestones

M1

Plan
Wk 1-2

M2

Prototype
Wk 3-5

M3

Vertical Slice
Wk 6-8

M4

Ship
Wk 9-10

Let's Build This.

+

Gameplay programmer

combat, typing, and ability systems

+

UI / tools programmer

shop, HUD, progression, save data

+

Artist

enemy sprites, base art, UI polish

